



BALANCING ACT: Manmohan has reaffirmed defence ties with Russia

MENDING FENCES

Despite delays in the supply of spares and weapon systems, India tries to shake off its US leaning by boosting defence ties with its traditional ally and largest arms supplier—Russia

■ **By Sandeep Unnithan**

It was the year of the chill in relations between India and Russia not just over delays in critical programmes—the purchase of a second-hand Russian aircraft carrier and the lease of a nuclear-powered attack submarine—but a perceived Indian tilt towards the United States. Yet, when Prime Minister Manmohan Singh returned from Russia, he had sealed a major joint development defence contract for the Multi-Role Transport Aircraft (MRTA) with Russia signalling it was business as usual between the two countries.

MRTA will enter service in 2012 and

RUSSIAN OFFER

- India to notify Russia of the remaining service life of its military equipment and spares required.
- Russian original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) will produce the spares in advance.
- Spares will be stocked with Russian OEMs as well as warehouses located in India. Will be made available to the armed forces whenever the demand arises.
- Spares will also be sold to regional states friendly to India and Russia.

replace India's fleet of ageing Soviet-built An-32 transport aircraft. During his visit to Russia last month, Defence Minister A.K. Antony inked an agreement to jointly design, develop and manufacture Fifth Generation Fighter Aircraft (FGFA), worth Rs 40,000 crore—the largest defence partnership between the two countries.

Yet it is a Russian proposal to resolve a decades-old thorny issue of lack of after-sales support and spare parts, that could be truly groundbreaking. Russia's state-owned arms trading firm Rosoboronexport, which operates directly under President Vladimir Putin, envisages setting up warehouses in Indian special eco-